James Lovelock



Inspired by writers such as Jules Verne and H.G. Wells, James Lovelock, born in 1919, was fascinated by science and invention from an early age. He graduated in chemistry from Manchester University in 1941. Lovelock was a conscientious objector during World War II and worked for the National Institute for Medical Research in London. In 1948, he received his Ph.D. in medicine, and then spent time in the US on a Rockefeller fellowship. After returning to Britain in 1955, he turned his attention to inventions, notably the electron-capture detector (ECD), which detects trace atoms in a gas sample. In the 1960s and 1970s, he held visiting professorships in Houston, Texas, and Reading, England, during which time he developed the Gaia hypothesis. In 2003, Lovelock was made a Companion of Honour by Queen Elizabeth II.

Key works

1988 *The Ages of Gaia*

1991 *Gaia: The Practical Science of Planetary Medicine*

2009 *The Vanishing Face of Gaia: A Final Warning*

"If there were a nuclear war, and humanity were wiped out, Earth would breathe a sigh of relief."

James Lovelock